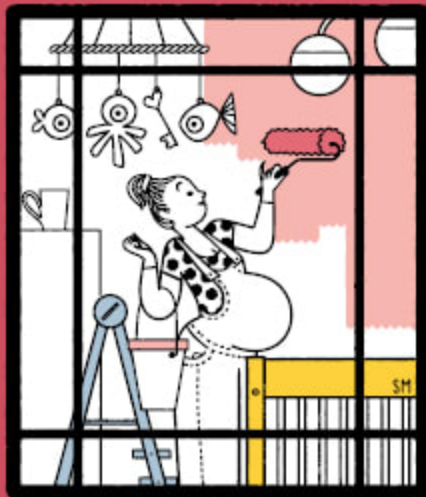


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Karantonis picks up challenger in County Board primary

By **Scott McCaffrey**

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Takis Karantonis and James DeVita (staff photo by Scott McCaffrey)

The Democratic field for the lone County Board seat on Arlington's 2025 ballot ticked up to two on Wednesday night (Jan. 8).

As expected, incumbent Takis Karantonis launched a re-election bid at the [monthly meeting](#) of the Arlington County Democratic Committee.

Just minutes later, James DeVita — who ran for County Board last year and in 2023 sought a Virginia Senate seat — also kicked off his campaign at the meeting, held at Lubber Run Community Center.

The two, and any other Democrats who might file before the April 3 deadline, will square off in a June 17 primary.

While apparently amiable toward one another, posing at one point for a joint photo, neither aspirant referenced the other during his three-minute kickoff speech. However,

the candidates did address themes they planned to focus on during the five months leading up to the primary election.

Karantonis hit on topics including economic development, climate, housing affordability and “taking practical steps” on controversial issues like zoning.

The incumbent said he wanted to ensure an “Arlington that every resident is proud to call home.”

DeVita emphasized education, and promoted the attraction of new businesses by temporarily lowering some tax rates and reducing bureaucratic hurdles.

As was the case when he ran last year, DeVita voiced [concern about residential upzoning](#) through the Missing Middle/Expanded Housing Options process currently being [fought out in court](#).

“I believe in ‘intelligent development,’” DeVita said.

Both took shots at the incoming Trump administration:

- **Karantonis:** “Local government is the one defense against what is coming from the White House. Let’s keep moving forward.”
- **DeVita:** “There are some things in life we have to fight for. I want to build [a political] army that can fight back.”

An economist and one-time executive director of the Columbia Pike Partnership, Karantonis was elected to the Board in a [July 2020 special election](#) necessitated by the death of Erik Gutshall after winning a fast-tracked [Democratic nominating process](#).

He was elected to a full term in 2021 after first defeating Chanda Choun in that year’s Democratic primary.

Karantonis on Jan. 7 was selected by his colleagues to chair the Board for 2025. The priorities he detailed in his campaign kickoff a day later largely mirrored themes he presented in his [first speech as Board chair](#).

An attorney, DeVita is hoping the third time is the charm for his electoral prospects.

In 2023, he garnered 16% of the vote in a primary challenge to Sen. Barbara Favola (D-40). A year later, he finished fourth out of five in the [Democratic County Board primary](#) won by JD Spain, Sr.

The seat of Karantonis is the only Board slot on the ballot this year. If any more Democrats throw their hat into the race, the primary will be held under ranked-choice-voting rules.

Also at the Jan. 8 meeting, [Victor Salgado](#) — a candidate for the Democratic nomination for lieutenant government and an Arlington resident — made his pitch to Arlington Democrats.

Party chair Steve Baker told ARLnow he expects more announcements for local office in February. Baker anticipates that, like Salgado, most of the Democratic contenders for statewide offices of governor, lieutenant governor and attorney general will attend committee meetings before the primary.

“We’re excited and raring to go,” Baker said of the 2025 political season.

About the Author



Scott McCaffrey

A Northern Virginia native, Scott McCaffrey has four decades of reporting, editing and newsroom experience in the local area plus Florida, South Carolina and the eastern panhandle of West Virginia. He spent 26 years as editor of the Sun Gazette newspaper chain.

For Local News Now, he covers government and civic issues in Arlington, Fairfax County and Falls Church.

#County Board

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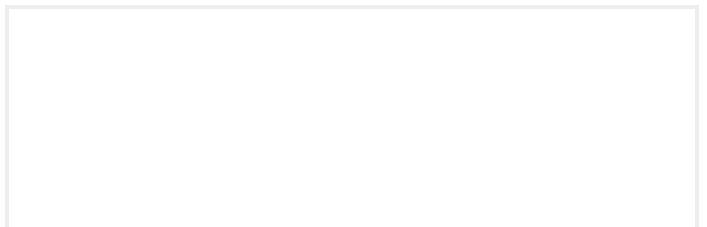
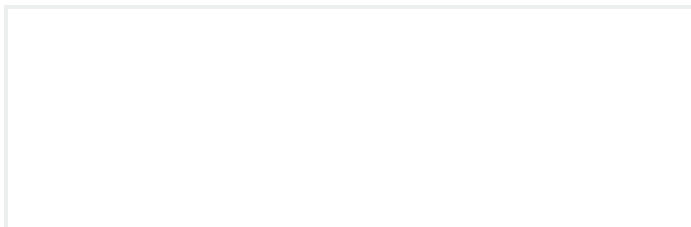


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